

APPENDIX 14 - SAMPLE PROFILE FROM THE OUTPUT OF THE QUALITATIVE CONTENT ANALYSIS

Below is a ‘profile’ of a case under study, meant to serve as sample preliminary outputs from Stage 1 of this dissertation. This appendix is meant to provide an indication of the richness and the depth of the content analysis, which fed subsequent Stages of this research project.¹ All 43 cases had a similar profile.

Digital Empowerment Foundation (Data Sovereignty organization)²

1. Organizational Information

Digital Empowerment Foundation (DEF) is a Delhi-based nonprofit organization dedicated to empowering marginalized communities through digital literacy and access to digital tools. DEF was registered in 2002 under the Indian Societies Registration Act, 1860, to bridge the digital divide and facilitate access to information and communication technologies (ICT) for socio-economic development. The foundation focuses on ensuring digital inclusion by establishing infrastructure and providing digital literacy training to communities, particularly in rural and underserved areas of India.

Mission: DEF aims “to empower marginalized communities in information-dark regions to access, consume, and produce information online using digital interventions and ICT tools.” The organization seeks to combat "information poverty" and facilitate equitable access to digital resources.

¹ This summary was developed in two steps. First, all the source materials across all the 43 cases were analyzed to identify 16 coding categories (11 eventually became condition types, 4 became outcome groups, and ‘Accountability’ serves Chapter 6 of the dissertation). Second, each case’s tagged information (highlighted in bold font in the example below) was organized according to those coding categories.

² Note: Text in bold font reflects text selection for researcher coding and categorization.

Vision: DEF envisions “an information-rich and digitally uplifted community through the extensive use of ICT and digital media tools.” The overarching goal is to create digital equity and eliminate barriers that prevent marginalized populations from accessing the benefits of digitalization.

Values and Principles: DEF adheres to core values of **empathy, equality, empowerment, transparency, and participatory governance**. These principles guide their work, ensuring inclusivity and engagement with the communities they serve. The organization emphasizes trust-building, proactive efforts, and a commitment to social change over financial gains.

Economic Sector: DEF operates in the **digital literacy and digital inclusion** sector, working across multiple domains such as education, livelihood, health, and governance. Their interventions include capacity-building programs, knowledge-sharing networks, and infrastructure projects to facilitate digital empowerment¹.

Geographic Scope: DEF operates across **25 states and 250+ districts in India**, with a focus on rural, tribal, and marginalized communities. Their reach extends internationally through collaborations and partnerships with global organizations advocating for digital inclusion and digital rights.

Leadership and Evolution: The organization was founded by **Osama Manzar**, a journalist-turned-digital advocate, who has played a key role in shaping DEF’s strategic direction. Over the years, DEF has expanded from localized ICT interventions to national-scale programs, influencing policy discussions and developing global partnerships.

Key Programs and Initiatives: DEF operates through six programmatic verticals:

1. **Access & Infrastructure** – Ensuring connectivity and digital literacy.
2. **Governance & Entitlements** – Promoting digital tools for governance and rights awareness.
3. **Education & Empowerment** – Enhancing digital skills for socio-economic growth.
4. **Markets & Social Enterprise** – Supporting micro-enterprises and digital entrepreneurship.
5. **Knowledge Hub & Database** – Developing a repository of ICT innovations.
6. **Advocacy & Research** – Engaging in policy advocacy for digital rights².

2. The Problem They Are Attempting to Solve

Digital Empowerment Foundation (DEF) was founded to address **information poverty** and the digital divide in India, particularly in rural and marginalized communities. The organization identifies lack of digital literacy, limited internet access, and the exclusion of vulnerable populations from the benefits of digital transformation as critical challenges. DEF works to bridge these gaps by ensuring **affordable and equitable access to digital tools, literacy programs, and ICT-enabled services**.

Key Challenges Identified by DEF:

1. **Digital Exclusion and Inequality:**
 - A large segment of India's population, especially in rural areas, remains disconnected from the internet.

- DEF reports that **70% of rural India lacks internet access**, while **50% of students lack connectivity for online education**.
- Women, persons with disabilities, and marginalized communities face additional barriers in digital participation.

2. **Lack of Digital Literacy and Skills:**

- Many rural citizens lack basic ICT skills, limiting their ability to **access government services, economic opportunities, and education**.
- DEF's digital literacy training programs aim to empower communities with functional and financial digital skills.

3. **Limited Access to Government Services and Rights:**

- The digital divide exacerbates social inequalities by restricting access to **welfare schemes, healthcare, employment, and education**.
- DEF's **Soochna Seva project** helps marginalized groups navigate and access government entitlements.

4. **Economic and Employment Barriers:**

- Digital exclusion limits micro-entrepreneurs, artisans, and small businesses from accessing **e-commerce, digital payments, and online markets**.
- DEF's programs like **SoochnaPreneur** and **Digital Sarthak** aim to create digital entrepreneurs, especially among women and youth.

5. **Threats to Digital Rights and Data Sovereignty:**

- DEF advocates against **data monopolization, exclusionary digital governance, and algorithmic discrimination.**
- The organization works on **internet governance, community networks, and digital rights advocacy** to ensure fair and inclusive digital policies.

Broader Structural Issues DEF Seeks to Address:

- **Surveillance and Data Colonialism:** DEF highlights how **biometric-based digital identity systems, such as Aadhaar, create new forms of exclusion** and vulnerability.
- **Gender Digital Divide:** Women in rural India face greater restrictions on mobile phone and internet access, reducing their economic and educational opportunities.
- **Sustainability of Digital Infrastructure:** Private telecom companies often ignore rural areas due to lower profitability, leaving large regions **disconnected from digital access.**

Through its **community-driven digital initiatives**, DEF aims to counteract these systemic issues by democratizing digital access, promoting digital justice, and ensuring technology serves **as a tool for empowerment rather than exclusion.**

3. The Politics That the Organization Expresses

Digital Empowerment Foundation (DEF) articulates a politics centered on **digital inclusion, equity, participation, and the democratization of technology.** It positions itself as an advocate for **digital rights, data sovereignty, and internet access as a fundamental human right.** DEF asserts that “access to information and digital know-how is a necessity and should not lead to exclusion,” and it actively works against the

deepening of inequalities through digital technologies. The foundation describes itself as an “integral digital action organization” that creates “information empowerment and equitable communities by providing digital access to information, knowledge, and contextual capacity”.

DEF frames digital inclusion as a means of **economic and social justice**. It takes a rights-based approach, stating that “serving the people is the overarching objective that takes precedence over anything else, including revenues and faster growth.” This commitment is reflected in its programs, which emphasize “transparency, good governance, and participative decision-making” to ensure that marginalized groups have control over their access to digital tools and services. The organization challenges the status quo of digital governance, arguing that “governments claim digital systems reduce corruption, but who do these systems actually serve? The ones who create them, or the ones who need them the most?” This critique is particularly relevant in the context of digital ID systems, where DEF highlights the risks of biometric surveillance and exclusion caused by faulty or restrictive digital infrastructure.

DEF promotes **community-led and decentralized digital governance models** as alternatives to corporate or state-controlled platforms. Its advocacy work focuses on ensuring that communities have autonomy over their digital tools and data. Through projects like **Wireless for Communities (W4C)** and **Community Networks**, DEF enables people to build and maintain their own internet infrastructure, demonstrating a model of digital empowerment that resists top-down control. The organization sees technology as a space of struggle: “We cannot solely depend on telcos or their model of

business to connect the 70 percent of the population that is yet to access the internet,” says founder Osama Manzar, advocating for policy changes in favor of **community networks**.

DEF also takes a strong stance against **digital colonialism**, particularly the monopolization of digital resources by large corporations and the exploitation of data from marginalized communities without their consent. It highlights the role of digital exclusion in reinforcing economic hierarchies and critiques the way global digital capitalism exacerbates inequality. The foundation engages in **activism and advocacy**, working alongside global digital rights organizations to push for policies that promote open and participatory digital governance.

At the core of DEF’s political stance is a **commitment to participatory democracy and social inclusion**. It works to ensure that digital literacy and connectivity serve as tools for strengthening democratic engagement, rather than reinforcing existing disparities. The organization’s political ethos is deeply tied to its grassroots work, where digital literacy is not just a skill but a means of reclaiming power in a world increasingly governed by digital systems.

4. Regulation

Digital Empowerment Foundation engages extensively with **policy and regulatory issues**, particularly in advocating for **universal internet access, data protection rights, and the expansion of community-based digital governance**. The foundation operates in a regulatory landscape where government policies significantly

influence digital access and exclusion, and it positions itself as a mediator between **citizens, technology, and policy frameworks**.

DEF critiques existing **digital governance policies**, particularly those that result in the exclusion of marginalized communities. It has been vocal about **flaws in India's Aadhaar-based digital identity system**, which has led to cases of disenfranchisement due to clerical errors or biometric failures. DEF describes these regulatory failures as instances of “death by data,” where flawed digital policies result in **denial of rights, food, wages, and essential services**.

The organization also advocates for **a more inclusive regulatory framework** for community networks. It argues that “a supportive policy framework such as the availability of TV White Space and liberalization of Internet Service Providers’ licenses at the Village Council level” would help bridge the digital divide in rural areas. DEF has worked alongside the **Internet Society (ISOC)** to push for policy changes that enable local, community-owned internet networks to flourish.

DEF’s advocacy extends to **intellectual property and open access policies**. It promotes **open-source digital tools and knowledge-sharing models** as alternatives to proprietary systems that restrict access and participation. In this regard, the foundation aligns itself with movements promoting **the digital commons and open internet**. It has been an active member of **national and global digital rights networks**, engaging with government panels and civil society forums to influence policy in favor of equitable digital access.

While DEF engages with government agencies, it does not align itself with state-led digital governance models uncritically. It participates in policy discussions but remains independent in its stance, advocating for regulatory approaches that prioritize community needs over corporate or centralized state control.

5. Social Context

DEF operates in the context of **India's growing digital economy and deepening digital divide**, where access to information is increasingly a determinant of economic and social mobility. The organization is embedded in **a landscape of rural and urban digital inequalities**, where the digital transition is happening unevenly. DEF describes itself as “working in information-dark regions” to create “digitally uplifted communities”.

DEF's work is shaped by **India's socio-economic stratification**, where **caste, class, gender, and geography** influence digital access. Women, tribal communities, and persons with disabilities face **additional layers of exclusion**, and DEF's programs specifically target these groups. The foundation highlights that **only 8.5% of women in rural India have meaningful access to the internet**, and its projects like **Digital Sarthak and SoochnaPreneur** focus on closing this gender gap.

DEF interacts with a wide array of **institutions, including NGOs, government agencies, and global digital rights organizations**. It collaborates with entities such as the **Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, UNESCO, and ISOC** to scale digital inclusion efforts while also partnering with **local governance bodies** to integrate digital tools into public service delivery.

6. Purpose

Digital Empowerment Foundation (DEF) articulates its purpose as a mission to “empower marginalized communities in information-dark regions to access, consume, and produce information online using digital interventions and ICT tools.” It defines its broader vision as ending “information poverty and social backwardness by bringing about a digital revolution” that ensures universal digital access, inclusion, and empowerment.

DEF’s work is deeply rooted in **digital justice, community empowerment, and democratization**, particularly in the **Global South**, where digital disparities exacerbate economic and social inequalities. The organization believes that **access to information and digital know-how is a necessity and should not lead to exclusion**, positioning digital literacy as a fundamental right rather than a privilege. DEF’s commitment to **economic justice, governance, and digital empowerment** is evident in its programmatic focus on digital literacy, online access, and community-driven digital solutions.

One of DEF’s key aims is to establish **community-led and locally governed digital infrastructures** that enable individuals and collectives to “demand better governance, better delivery of government services, and better protection of their basic human rights using digital literacy and digital tools.” This approach aligns with its advocacy for **data sovereignty and equitable access to digital resources**, ensuring that communities have both the **technical skills and institutional mechanisms** to participate in digital governance and economic opportunities.

DEF states that “our main currency, instead of money, is to bring about a deeper change,” underscoring its belief in **community-driven digital transformation** as a pathway to long-term equity. The foundation takes a **rights-based approach** in its advocacy, emphasizing transparency, fairness, and participatory governance as essential to **bridging the digital divide**. Its commitment is evident in its policy advocacy work, where it challenges data monopolies and exclusionary digital frameworks, arguing that digital policies must prioritize **equity and inclusion over profit and surveillance**.

7. How They Are Governed

Digital Empowerment Foundation is structured as a **not-for-profit organization** registered under the **Indian Societies Registration Act, 1860**. It maintains a governance model that is explicitly committed to **transparency, inclusion, and participatory decision-making**. The foundation states that “we ensure transparency, good governance, and participative decision-making based on a deep commitment to equality and fairness”.

DEF’s governance emphasizes **community-driven digital infrastructure**. A central aspect of its model is the **Community Information Resource Centers (CIRCs)**, which serve as decentralized hubs for digital literacy and internet access. These centers are run by **local community representatives**, allowing for a participatory governance structure that ensures community ownership of digital knowledge and tools.

DEF has a **widespread network of 10,000 digital foot soldiers** who act as grassroots enablers of digital transformation across **25 states and 250+ districts** in rural and marginalized areas. This decentralized implementation strategy ensures that

governance structures remain **flexible and community-led**, allowing local adaptations based on specific needs and conditions.

The organization also engages in **institutional collaborations** with **global and national bodies**, including **government agencies, international NGOs, and grassroots organizations**, ensuring that its governance model integrates multiple stakeholder interests while prioritizing the needs of marginalized communities. DEF's governance also extends to **policy advocacy**, where it actively engages with national and international regulatory bodies to push for **open and participatory digital governance frameworks**.

8. Resources That Sustain Their Activity and Impact

Digital Empowerment Foundation sustains its activities through a **diverse range of funding sources**, including **grants, philanthropic foundations, corporate partnerships, and international donors**. The foundation is supported by **governmental and non-governmental organizations**, leveraging both **public and private sector funding** to scale its initiatives.

DEF secures financial resources through collaborations with **global organizations such as UNESCO, the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, the European Union, and the Internet Society (ISOC)**. These partnerships provide DEF with the financial stability needed to run large-scale digital literacy campaigns, infrastructure projects, and research initiatives focused on **digital inclusion, data governance, and internet accessibility**.

Beyond financial contributions, DEF produces **valuable resources in the form of publications, digital knowledge hubs, and advocacy networks**. It has created a **database of effective ICTD (Information and Communication Technology for Development) interventions**, serving as a knowledge-sharing platform for practitioners, researchers, and policymakers. The foundation also runs **awards and recognition programs**, such as the **mBillionth Award and Manthan Award**, which highlight digital innovations that contribute to social empowerment.

DEF's **Community Information Resource Centers (CIRCs)** act as **self-sustaining digital hubs**, where **local communities contribute to and manage their own digital literacy programs and online services**. These centers generate **localized revenue streams** by providing **affordable digital services, access to government schemes, and digital financial literacy programs**. The organization's **SoochnaPreneur initiative**, which enables individuals to become **digital entrepreneurs providing e-governance and ICT services**, is another example of how DEF fosters **sustainable digital ecosystems** that do not rely solely on external funding.

DEF's ability to sustain itself is also strengthened by its **policy advocacy and research initiatives**, which allow it to shape regulatory frameworks and secure institutional backing for its long-term vision of **universal digital access**. Through these strategies, DEF ensures that its work remains **financially viable, community-driven, and globally relevant**.

9. Who Are Their Partners?

Digital Empowerment Foundation (DEF) has built a **wide network of partnerships** spanning **government agencies, international organizations, civil society groups, private sector entities, and grassroots organizations**. These partnerships enable DEF to **scale its digital inclusion initiatives, influence policy, and expand community-driven digital governance models**. DEF actively collaborates with national and international stakeholders to advance its **mission of digital equity and data sovereignty**.

DEF has **strong collaborations with global institutions**, including **UNESCO, the European Union, the Internet Society (ISOC), the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, and the Tata Trusts**. These organizations provide **financial support, technical expertise, and advocacy platforms** that help DEF **expand its digital literacy programs, research initiatives, and community-driven digital interventions**.

DEF's **government partnerships** have been instrumental in expanding its reach. It has worked with the **Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), the Ministry of Minority Affairs, and the National Internet Exchange of India (NIXI)** to implement projects like the **National Digital Literacy Mission (NDLM), Digital Panchayat, and Soochna Seva**, which aim to integrate digital access into public governance and welfare services.

DEF also partners with **corporate entities and technology organizations** that support its **digital skilling and entrepreneurship programs**. For example, its **SoochnaPreneur initiative** has received support from **Qualcomm under its Wireless**

Reach program, enabling rural youth to become digital entrepreneurs. DEF has also collaborated with **Vodafone Foundation, Google India, and Facebook** on digital literacy campaigns aimed at increasing online safety and access for marginalized communities.

In addition to global and corporate partnerships, DEF has deep ties with **civil society and community organizations**. It is an **active member of the Association for Progressive Communications (APC)** and collaborates with **grassroots NGOs across India** to ensure that digital tools are used for **economic empowerment, community governance, and social justice**. Its work with **rural self-help groups, local NGOs, and panchayat-level institutions** helps bring **digital knowledge and resources to the most underserved populations**.

Through these partnerships, DEF leverages **financial, technological, and human resources** to ensure that **community-led digital governance models** are **sustainable and scalable**. These collaborations help DEF challenge the **dominant models of digital exclusion** and advocate for **policies that promote digital rights, access, and empowerment**.

10. What Are Their Practices When It Comes to Technology?

DEF is deeply engaged in **digital innovation and grassroots technology adoption**, viewing technology as a **tool for empowerment, governance, and social transformation**. The organization takes a **community-first approach** to technology deployment, ensuring that digital tools are **accessible, affordable, and participatory**. DEF promotes **open-source solutions, community networks, and decentralized digital**

governance models to counter the dominant **corporate and state-controlled digital systems**.

The foundation has pioneered **community-owned digital networks** through projects like **Wireless for Communities (W4C)**, which enables villages to **set up and maintain their own internet infrastructure** using **unlicensed spectrum**. DEF believes that digital access should be **locally governed**, and it has been an advocate for **policy changes that allow rural communities to control their own digital ecosystems**.

DEF also **champions digital commons and data sovereignty**, pushing for models where **communities, not corporations, own and control their digital assets**. Through initiatives like **Digital Panchayat** and **Soochna Seva**, the foundation has integrated **digital tools into governance systems**, ensuring that communities have a say in how technology shapes their access to **rights, welfare schemes, and economic opportunities**.

The organization actively promotes **functional and critical digital literacy**. DEF states that “we relate technology to the masses, especially on how technology can empower women, youth, differently-abled, and elderly people in functional digital literacy, media literacy, and digital upskilling”. Its training programs focus on **practical skills**, such as **financial literacy, digital entrepreneurship, and civic engagement**, rather than merely teaching people how to use devices.

DEF also takes a strong stance on **technology ethics and digital justice**, advocating against **surveillance capitalism, data monopolization, and algorithmic discrimination**. It engages in **research and policy advocacy** to challenge **extractive**

digital business models and promote **equitable, community-driven alternatives**. It has collaborated with the **Internet Society and digital rights groups** to advance discussions on **ethical AI, platform accountability, and open-access digital infrastructures**.

Overall, DEF's technological practices reflect its **values of participation, transparency, and democratization**. The organization ensures that **digital tools are not just used by communities but also governed by them**, challenging the dominant paradigms of **top-down, profit-driven technology governance**.

11. What Technology, Tools, or Data Do They Use in Their Work?

DEF deploys a **broad range of digital technologies, platforms, and community-driven tools** to promote **digital inclusion, governance, and entrepreneurship**. One of its key approaches is the **Community Information Resource Center (CIRC) model**, which serves as **a physical and digital infrastructure hub** where individuals can **learn digital skills, access government services, and participate in local governance**.

The foundation has developed **custom-built digital platforms** to help communities navigate and access public services. **MeraApp**, for instance, is an Android-based mobile application that allows rural users to **find welfare schemes and government entitlements** in their local languages. Users can also file grievances and track the status of their applications through the app.

DEF's **Wireless for Communities (W4C) project** has established **low-cost internet networks** in rural areas using **TV White Space and unlicensed spectrum**. The

organization **trains local youth** to maintain these networks, ensuring that connectivity remains a **community-governed resource** rather than a corporate-controlled service.

The foundation also supports **open-source digital content and knowledge-sharing platforms**. Through projects like **Gyanpedia** and **Digital Knowledge Hub**, DEF has created **repositories of local knowledge, digital literacy materials, and case studies on ICT for development**. These platforms enable communities to **document and share their experiences, ensuring that digital knowledge remains a common resource**.

DEF integrates **data-driven approaches into social impact measurement**, using **community-generated data** to track the effectiveness of its interventions. The foundation collects and analyzes data on **digital literacy rates, access to welfare programs, and community-led digital initiatives**, helping refine its strategies and advocate for **inclusive digital policies**.

Through these technologies, DEF ensures that **digital tools serve as enablers of equity and justice**, rather than instruments of exclusion or surveillance.

12. How Is the Organization Producing Democracy, in Terms of Their Practices?

DEF advances **democratic digital governance** by ensuring that communities have direct control over their **digital infrastructure, data, and decision-making processes**. It asserts that “participatory governance and digital inclusion should be the foundation of a just and democratic digital future”.

The foundation promotes **community-driven internet access** through projects like **Wireless for Communities**, where **local residents are trained to build and**

maintain their own networks. This model ensures **decentralized control over digital infrastructure**, preventing corporate monopolization of internet access.

DEF fosters **digital democracy by increasing access to governance and civic participation tools.** Through **Digital Panchayat and Soochna Seva**, DEF has helped rural citizens engage with **local governance, demand transparency, and participate in policy decisions.**

By embedding **participation, local governance, and transparency** into digital systems, DEF ensures that **technology strengthens, rather than undermines, democratic engagement.**

13. Does the Organization Contribute to Community Wealth, Is It Producing Economic Value for Its Communities, or Is It Extracting Value from Communities?

Digital Empowerment Foundation (DEF) explicitly frames its mission around **community wealth building through digital empowerment.** It operates under the belief that “access to digital tools and knowledge should not lead to exclusion but instead enable communities to thrive economically and socially”. Unlike corporate digital models that **extract value from user data and digital labor**, DEF works to **redistribute digital access and economic opportunities to marginalized communities.**

One of the central ways DEF contributes to community wealth is by fostering **digital entrepreneurship.** Through programs like **SoochnaPreneur**, DEF enables rural youth and women to become **digital entrepreneurs (information entrepreneurs)** who provide **digital financial services, e-governance facilitation, and access to digital marketplaces** in their villages. These **locally-embedded digital service**

providers generate income while ensuring that communities can navigate and benefit from the digital economy.

DEF has also **digitally empowered micro and nano enterprises**, particularly **artisan clusters and small-scale industries**. Projects like **DigiKargha** have helped artisans **connect with online markets, develop digital literacy skills, and use technology to preserve traditional crafts while increasing their economic resilience**. These interventions allow communities to **retain control over their digital assets and economic transactions, rather than being exploited by platform capitalism**.

The foundation further **enhances economic value at the community level by establishing locally-governed digital infrastructures** such as **Community Information Resource Centers (CIRCs)**. These centers function as **self-sustaining hubs**, offering digital literacy training, online services, and micro-business incubation opportunities. They also provide access to **government welfare programs, financial literacy resources, and local digital job opportunities**, directly contributing to **economic resilience in marginalized areas**.

DEF's work on **digital financial inclusion** is another way it generates community wealth. The foundation actively **promotes digital payments, financial literacy, and e-commerce integration for small businesses**, ensuring that marginalized groups can participate in the formal economy. Through collaborations with **banks, government agencies, and fintech platforms**, DEF has helped rural populations transition to **secure digital financial systems**, enabling them to build **savings, access credit, and expand economic opportunities**.

By focusing on **economic empowerment rather than extraction**, DEF challenges the dominant **corporate-led data economy**, where digital platforms profit from the **commodification of user behavior and digital labor**. Instead, it supports models of **community-led digital governance and wealth distribution**, ensuring that digital participation directly benefits those who need it most.

14. How Do They Find Balance Between Their Local and “Global” Priorities?

Digital Empowerment Foundation (DEF) **actively bridges local digital empowerment with global digital justice movements**, balancing its **grassroots interventions with transnational advocacy and collaboration**. While its **core focus remains on digital inclusion in India**, DEF engages with **global networks, international policy discussions, and cross-border digital equity initiatives** to advocate for **community-led technology governance on a global scale**.

DEF's **local impact** is seen through its **direct engagement with rural communities**, where it sets up **Community Information Resource Centers (CIRCs), digital skilling programs, and community network infrastructure**. These interventions are designed to address **local needs**, such as **lack of internet access, digital illiteracy, and exclusion from government services**, ensuring that marginalized communities gain **functional digital participation**.

At the same time, DEF has an **active presence in global internet governance forums**, advocating for **digital rights, open-access policies, and community-led internet infrastructure**. It collaborates with organizations like **the Internet Society (ISOC), UNESCO, and the Association for Progressive Communications (APC)** to

influence global discussions on **digital equity, data sovereignty, and decentralized internet models.**

DEF also operates as a **regional knowledge hub** for digital inclusion, frequently **publishing research on digital rights, platform governance, and grassroots digital economies.** Its research outputs contribute to **global dialogues on decolonizing digital technology and ensuring community control over digital resources,** aligning with broader movements for **platform cooperativism, data commons, and alternative technology models.**

In practice, DEF **synthesizes global best practices with local adaptations.** It takes lessons from **international community network models** and applies them to **India's digital landscape,** while also exporting its own **community-led governance strategies** to global partners. Through this **bidirectional exchange,** DEF ensures that **local priorities inform global digital policy frameworks,** and global advocacy efforts **translate into meaningful local interventions.**

15. What Is the Impact They Are Looking to Achieve, or Have a Record of Already Achieving?

DEF has **directly impacted more than 35 million people** across **25 states and 250+ districts** in India through its **digital literacy programs, community networks, and digital governance initiatives.** The foundation's goal is to **eradicate information poverty and establish community-controlled digital infrastructures** that empower individuals socially, politically, and economically.

DEF has established **over 2,000 Community Information Resource Centers (CIRCs)**, serving as **rural digital hubs** that provide **internet access, e-governance services, and digital training**. Through these centers, it has facilitated access to **government welfare schemes, financial services, and skill development programs**, ensuring that **marginalized communities can fully participate in the digital economy**.

One of DEF's key impact areas is **women's digital empowerment**. Through projects like **Digital Sarthak and SoochnaPreneur**, DEF has trained **over 4 million women in digital and financial literacy**, equipping them with skills for **entrepreneurship, online work, and civic engagement**. These initiatives have **created employment opportunities for thousands of rural women**, enabling them to **generate income through digital services**.

DEF has also made a significant **policy and advocacy impact**, influencing discussions on **internet governance, digital rights, and data sovereignty** at national and international levels. It has contributed to **research on digital exclusion, algorithmic discrimination, and open-access internet policies**, shaping **policy frameworks that prioritize community-led digital governance**.

In terms of infrastructure, DEF has helped **connect over 150 rural communities to locally governed internet networks**, ensuring that digital access is **not solely dependent on commercial telecom providers**. Through its **Wireless for Communities (W4C)** initiative, it has demonstrated that **community-owned networks can be sustainable, cost-effective, and empowering**.

The foundation continues to scale its impact, with plans to establish **3,000+ additional CIRCs across 28 states** and train **100,000 digital foot soldiers** to expand **digital entrepreneurship and governance programs** in the coming years.

16. How Are They Accountable to Their Stakeholders and Communities?

DEF emphasizes **transparency, participatory governance, and local accountability** as fundamental principles in its digital empowerment work. The foundation states that it **prioritizes community participation in decision-making processes** to ensure that **digital interventions align with local needs**.

A major mechanism of accountability is its **Community Information Resource Centers (CIRC)s**, which are **locally managed** and provide **public access to information, grievance redressal services, and e-governance support**. These centers function as **transparent, community-run institutions**, where local representatives **monitor program effectiveness and adapt services to community priorities**.

DEF also holds **regular consultations with its stakeholders**, including **community members, partner organizations, and government agencies**, to ensure that its projects remain **inclusive, equitable, and impactful**. It engages in **open data-sharing practices, publishing impact reports, case studies, and research findings** to maintain **accountability and public trust**.

Through these mechanisms, DEF ensures that its work remains **community-driven, participatory, and transparent**, reinforcing **democratic accountability in digital governance**.

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